



have improved drastically. For my achievement at the Junior Worlds, I received support from the government. Now, athletes get similar support much earlier — after a Khelo India Games medal or a win at the Nationals. Previously, we had to secure international medals to receive the same backing. That is a positive change,” Navdeep says.

Tokyo setback to Paris triumph

Navdeep scrolls through his phone’s gallery, searching for a video of his meeting with Prime Minister Narendra Modi following his return from the Tokyo Paralympics in 2021. He had missed out on a bronze medal by just 60 centimetres, finishing fourth with a best throw of 40.80 metres.

Unable to find the video, he turns to his old ally — YouTube. He skips to the part where he promised the Prime Minister that he would win a medal at the next Paralympics.

Three years later, in Paris, Navdeep kept his word. With a best

throw of 47.32 metres, he not only secured the gold medal but also shattered the Paralympic record in the F41 category.

“I think the first feeling was that I had removed the ‘loser’ tag that people had put on me after I finished fourth in Tokyo. I was satisfied that I had proven myself and that I was not a ‘loser’ just because someone else said so. That emotion came out in front of the camera and went viral,” Navdeep recalls.

Having faced societal rejection due to his genetic condition, Navdeep relied on introspection to carve a successful path in sport. It helped him navigate the Tokyo setback and played a pivotal role in his comeback.

“Bohot zyada farak padta hai (What people say affects you). Even if someone makes a small comment about you, you start thinking about it. You wonder, ‘Why is that person saying this?’ If it happens repeatedly, you begin to doubt yourself — ‘Am I really like this?’ ‘If people say you’re

Moment to savour: Navdeep Singh celebrates with his gold medal in the men's javelin throw F41 event at the 2024 Paris Paralympics. REUTERS

not good, you start searching for faults within yourself. I have been through that phase. But then I worked on myself — how I could improve, understanding my strengths and weaknesses. I cut out all distractions, and the path became clear,” Navdeep says.

Although he blushes at being called a celebrity, fame has followed him post his triumph in Paris. He is an Arjuna awardee, frequently recognised in public, and often gets selfie requests. More importantly, he has nothing to prove anymore.

“A person should never be stagnant. I just want to keep improving. When you aim to keep getting better, you always set new targets to achieve, and that is what I want to keep doing,” Navdeep says.